Research Skills

Research Skills Foundations -- Case Studies: Source Types

Using Newspapers as Historical Sources

DOI: https://doi.org/10.47594/RMPS_0105

Citation: Wong, Matthias Meng Yan, "Case Studies: Source Types - Using Newspapers as Historical Sources" in *AM Research Skills Foundations* (Marlborough: AM, 2021)

© Adam Matthew Digital Limited 2021

Abstract

A world without news is almost unimaginable. As inquisitive and social animals, we want to know about the world around us and of the latest news of import. Before the advent of the newspaper, the news was spread widely and over long distances through letters and word-of-mouth. The advent of mass printing allowed people to reproduce set texts at a cheap price, creating a national news media that meant a farmer in the rural countryside could read the same news and opinion as a banker in the heart of the city.

Newspapers are valuable sources for historical research. A product of the printing age, newspapers were published to communicate information and the news to a wide audience. They contain a vast array of material that is useful to historians of every stripe. Although they may profess their impartiality, like any other source, newspapers have certain limitations that a researcher needs to keep in mind. This case study will explore how you can use newspapers fruitfully. By looking at two newspapers – the *Asiatic Mirror* and *Harrop's Manchester Mercury* – in detail, we will discuss the best ways of approaching these sources, and how we can best utilise them for historical research.

Author

Matthias Meng Yan Wong (National University of Singapore, Singapore)

Matthias Wong is Senior Tutor in the Department of History, National University of Singapore. His research examines how violence in early modern England affected notions of time and the future. He is particularly interested in the publications of astrologers, historians, and journalists. He received his PhD from the University of Cambridge, where he studied as a NUS-Cambridge Trust Scholar.

Learning Outcomes

After reading this case study, you will be able to:

- Recognise the main features of a newspaper.
- Understand how newspapers have evolved over time.
- Formulate questions that can be usefully asked of these sources, while keeping in mind their inherent limitations.
- Visualise how to use these source types in a research project.

Initial Steps and Questions

Before reading this piece and evaluating the primary source in full, you may want to reflect on these questions and initial steps:

1. What form do these sources take? Are you looking at the originals or photocopies and scans of the document? What information do we have about this collection, and how does it change the way we approach the source itself?

2. What is the coverage of these sources? Who is the intended audience, and what types of information and content are being prioritised?

3. How many issues do we have? Do we know how successful the paper was, or how long it ran for? Collections of newspapers can vary, from the full runs of short-lived papers to small collections of scattered issues of a well-established and long-running institution. What questions can we fruitfully ask of different types of collections?

4. What do we know of the creators of the source? What motives and values did they bring to bear when creating these sources?

5. Is there any evidence of reader interaction with the source? Are there any annotations or changes to the text that might reflect how the source was understood?

Contextual Information

Newspapers as a Primary or Secondary Source

The most straightforward way to use a newspaper is as a secondary source of information. A newspaper exists to communicate the news and important information: through their reports of what happened at any given date and time, historians can find important information about past events. However, there are important caveats any researcher should be aware of.

First, newspapers are not ‘mirrors’ of reality. There is simply too much information to fit within any individual issue. A common event like a traffic accident may not normally feature in a newspaper unless it involves someone thought to be noteworthy. Newspapers are gatekeepers of information as a matter of practicality. Editors and publishers filter the information they receive, deeming some newsworthy and others not important enough to include. Newspapers thus reflected what their creators thought was useful and important, and they are presented in a manner that replicated the way they saw the world. By filtering, organising, and presenting information, newspapers structure and construct a distorted reflection of reality for their readers.

Second, newspaper content was shaped not just by their creators but also by their readers. Newspapers are commercial operations that play to a perceived audience in an effort to remain viable and competitive in the marketplace. They distinguish themselves by their speed and content, by being the first to report important news, or by featuring content tailored to a segment of the population. Much like today’s news marketplace, the newspapers of the past tailored their tone and selection of news to their target audience. To remain viable, their content and editorial views needed to resonate with their audiences. Censorship could also play a role in determining what content is published. Newspapers that depended on advertisements for revenue would also have had to consider how their content might affect their advertisers and their willingness to do business.

The authorship of a newspaper and its constituent parts is also hard to determine. In large modern papers, content would be created, altered, and positioned by a plethora of individuals, including the writer(s), various editors, graphic designers, and printers. Even with newspapers in earlier centuries, it was unusual that only one person was responsible for writing and printing the document. For example, in the early modern period, while writers collated information and penned their editorials, they had to work closely with a printer that set their manuscripts and arranged their words and the bookseller or publisher who would help hawk their wares.[1] Many content items were copied from letters bearing news, a practice that continued into the eighteenth-century as we will see in our sources, and to this day with print syndication and news agencies.

This has several implications for their use as historical sources. Newspapers are not akin to scholarly chronicles of information. Striving to be timely, newspapers publish without the benefit of hindsight and important information that would only surface later. Their sources could also be mistaken or even motivated to mislead. Newspapers can perpetuate 'common knowledge' that is factually incorrect.[2] Working with limitations of space and information availability and catering to their audience and their own values, a newspaper presents a curated view of reality. It is the historian's job to take these factors into account and to gauge how reliable and complete the source's information is.

A newspaper can nonetheless capture important information and material that may otherwise be lost forever. By reproducing eyewitness accounts, interviews, and speeches, newspapers record the thoughts and utterances of past individuals. These accounts can be invaluable, particularly if they come from individuals that may otherwise not be represented in the documentary record. As a periodical, you can consult consecutive issues to track the coverage of particular events or people, and also to chart change in society and the economy over time. Printed in large numbers and distributed widely, newspaper issues can sometimes survive when other, less numerous, types of sources do not.

A researcher can thus use a newspaper as a secondary source of information, as long as they cast a critical eye over its content and presentation. Who owned the paper? Is it affiliated with a political, religious, advocacy, or community group? What were its main sources of revenue? Was it aimed to a particular socioeconomic class? Comparing its content to other sources, does the paper omit or emphasise particular topics or information?[3] By cross-referencing other newspapers and other types of sources and by investigating the institutional history of the newspaper, a historian can place the newspaper in its proper context and use it fruitfully. Joad Raymond refers to early modern newsbooks as 'literary texts, which can provide historical information', which is a characterisation which can probably be extended to all news media.[4]

Another equally useful way to use newspapers is as a primary source of public opinion. By constructing a particular vision of reality, newspapers affected their readers' behaviour and worldview. Whether their information was accurate is immaterial; it is only important that the readers believed the news and acted on that belief. Newspapers are also carriers of popular beliefs, whether accurate or not. Newspapers exist to be consumed and only survive if viable. Thus, if their content resonated with a section of the reading public, their views represent a significant voice in society that should not be ignored by historians.[5]

We might expect that as cheap print was created in greater numbers than books and manuscripts, newspapers survive in greater numbers as historical sources. Unfortunately, because they were considered ephemeral pieces that go out of date, these sources were also discarded in greater numbers. Individual collectors like George Thomason were unusual in collecting print publications of every kind during the English Civil Wars. Printers sometimes tried to capitalise on the collecting instinct by numbering issues and collecting them into volumes. Some printers even used continuous pagination across issues, making each issue part of a larger 'book'.[6]

Historians engage with newspapers because they have the power to shape public debate and even affect government policy.[7] In Britain, the power of the popular press was evident by the mid-nineteenth century. Commentators

and writers like Thomas Carlyle and Charles Mitchell observed how the press steered the tone and content of the country's national conversations.[8] Early histories of newspapers tended to adopt the Whiggish assumptions of the time; they narrated the rise of an unrestrained public press alongside the inexorable increase in civil liberties and democratic rights.[9] Social historians of the 1960s challenged these accounts, arguing that the press did not represent the voice of the people. Radical newspapers that reflected the views of working people were outcompeted by papers backed by richer owners, and it was these monied papers that survived in a capitalistic economy like Britain. The linguistic turn in more recent times has also raised questions about the role newspapers have in constructing, perpetuating, and challenging ideas like race, identity and power.[10] Newspapers serve as both agents and forums of ideological contestation.

Researchers' use of newspapers has traditionally been stymied by practical concerns of time. With modern titles comprising hundreds to thousands of issues, it is difficult for a historian to manually search and identify relevant material. Thus, in the pre-digitisation age, historians often worked with 'papers of record' like the *Times* and the *Manchester Guardian*. These establishment publications, the 'quality' press, were considered mature and consequential actors in the public debate around politics and policy, and their pages were understood to contain important opinions and discourse that shaped the national conversation. Because of their perceived status, these papers were better catalogued, indexed, and preserved for research.[11] In contrast, 'popular newspapers' were thought of as 'predictable, trivial, unsophisticated, usually politically and socially conservative and prone to episodes of irrational sensationalism', and hence less worthy of scholarly attention.[12] Provincial and smaller papers suffered similarly from perceived insignificance.[13] Information about the newspapers themselves is also sparse, even for established papers like the *Times*. As commercial and private businesses, newspaper organisations have no incentive to document their process of creating their products. Which advertisements were accepted? Which articles were deemed unnewsworthy, and how were these editorial decisions made? Valuable marked copies of these papers, which identify contributors for accounting purposes, were routinely disposed of. This was compounded by scholars' lack of interest in newspapers' organisational history.[14]

With the digitisation efforts of the past two decades, researchers are now able to use keyword searches to find, in over thousands of issues, where their subject of interest was mentioned. With the time saved, we can widen our inquiries to more newspaper titles and thus be more comprehensive in our coverage of source material. Smaller papers are also now able to share their past issues more easily online. We can also analyse how frequently a word or idea was used and then determine whether that meaning changed over time. However, digitisation brings a different set of methodological concerns. Keyword searching is effective only if the sources themselves were using the same terminology, and a text search may exclude relevant images. Viewing newspapers on the screen can divorce the researcher from the materiality of the source itself, including the size of the sheet and the general presentation of the newspaper.[15] Having a good understanding of the society you are studying and of the material nature of the source itself is still essential to producing good research. The usefulness of keyword search is also restricted by the ability of the optical character recognition (OCR) technology used. OCR is generally more accurate for modern texts, and it is progressively less accurate for older printed texts.[16] Human transcription remains the most accurate but it is an extremely expensive and time-consuming option. Mass digitisation has nonetheless made newspapers a much more accessible source-type, allowing researchers to delve into this important source material. As we get more access to more and more newspapers, we can now better appreciate how each newspaper differs in content, approach, and form.

Source Analysis Questions

1. How often were issues published? How is each issue laid out? What are the main features of each issue?

2. What do we know about this source and its provenance? What do we know about the creator of the source, and how the newspaper was funded? Does it feature advertisements? If they do, what kinds?

3. What information can we glean from the newspaper about the world it was reporting about? What sources of information does it use?

4. What is the editorial stance of the paper? What information did it furnish, and what did it prioritise?

5. How do these newspapers shape the way their readers understood the world?

6. What are the limitations of these sources, and how can we address them?

Critical Evaluation

Source 1: Asiatic Mirror

Provenance and Contextual Information

Before we turn to the source itself, we should check its provenance and see if we can understand how it came to the archive. With a quick online search, we can see that these issues come from the Early Indian Newspapers Collection, held in the British Library.[17] A search on the British Library catalogue turns up the item's catalogue record.[18] Like the summary record for the Collection, the item record identifies Calcutta as the place of publication. It lists the four issues (276, 284, 296, and 526) that we see in our images.

The Collection record states that the *Asiatic Mirror* is one of several titles that were part of the Newspaper Library in Colindale, which was itself part of the British Museum Library. No other details of the item's accession (the process of adding a new item to a collection) are available from this cursory inquiry. From our survey, it appears that we have little contextual information to work with to understand the institutional history or audience of the newspaper.

Initial Evaluation

Without much external context, we will have to look at the internal evidence that the source presents. Looking at the first image, you can see the masthead prominently featured at the top. For a clearer view, see the second issue's first page (image 6). The title *Asiatic Mirror* and *Commercial Advertiser* provides some clues about the newspaper's audience. First, the term 'mirror' is commonly used in newspaper titles to assert their impartiality as a true reflection of reality. The figure with the winged boots and the Caduceus is that of Mercury, the Roman messenger of the gods. 'Mercury' is another common term used by newspapers in their titles, including Source 2, *Harrop's Manchester Mercury*. The quote on the banner reads 'Nothing extenuate nor

hold up Aught in Malice', a line from Shakespeare's *Othello*, where Othello asks that he be remembered after his death exactly as he was without exaggeration and without malice. In this case, the line appears to function as a motto to report the news factually and without prejudice. Second, 'Asiatic' is a good clue that the paper provides news from Asia, while 'Commercial Advertiser' probably means that its target audience comprised of merchants and the moneyed class who were interested in trade and the economy.

Surveying our source images, you can see the four issues as indicated in the source details. To figure out the frequency of the paper, we can compare the issue numbers and the date. Notice that all the issues were published on Wednesday (images 1, 6, 10, 14). This is not surprising; most newspapers before the twentieth century were weekly. Between our first two issues, 276 and 285, there are eight issues and eight weeks between 22 May and 17 July 1793. Similarly, there are twelve issues between 284 and 296 and twelve weeks between their publication dates of 17 July and 9 October 1793. Did this weekly publication schedule extend to our last surviving issue in 1798? Using a historical calendar that you can easily find online, you can count 236 weeks between 9 October 1793 and 7 March 1798. There are 230 issues between issues 296 and 526. This means that the paper published an issue regularly between 1793 and 1798, missing only six issues over four years. It seems that the *Asiatic Mirror* was a long-running enterprise that remained viable for years with consistent support from its readership and advertisers.

As for the volume number, we can hazard a guess that each volume corresponds to a year. The first three issues (1, 6, 10) are in Volume VI and the last issues (14) in Vol XI. With five years in between them, it appears that issues in a new year may have been designated as a new volume. Running issue numbers help readers distinguish between issues, and together with volume numbers, they also encourage collecting. On image 13, near the bottom of column four, there is an advertisement that 'Complete Sets' of the *Asiatic Mirror* were 'For sale at the Printing Office'. As a volume, the compiled issues would read like a historical chronicle of events and news of that year.

If you look at image 14, at the bottom right corner you will see a ruler that helps denote the scale of the scanned image and hence the size of the sheet. The original would be around 30 cm across and 50 cm tall, which is roughly the

size of a folio book (30 cm by 48 cm). A folio book is produced by folding a large sheet of paper in half, resulting in a book with two leaves that can contain up to four printed pages. This is a common size for newspapers of this period, and it is the exact format of the *Asiatic Mirror*. Conversely, early modern newsbooks were usually in quarto size, where you fold the same large sheet of paper twice to make four leaves. Trimming along the folds would result in eight pages that were half the size of the folio pages.

As you survey the source images, you may notice several modern symbols of books, like those on 1, 6, and 15. Like the scale ruler, these were probably added in to assist the reader in understanding the original condition of the source. From the black-and-white colour scheme and scanning marks, you may have surmised that these images were created from a microform copy of the original source. To help researchers access these sources, libraries and archives created copies on film, usually as microfilm (reel format) or as microfiche (card format). These formats were small and easy to store, and they could be reproduced and sent to other research libraries around the world. In this case, without a legend and with just several instances of these symbols, we can only make educated guesses as to what they mean. On 15, the image probably informs us that a leaf is missing from the original. If you compare this issue to others in this source, you will notice that it is missing two pages. The last page of every issue contains a printer's imprint at the bottom: 'Calcutta: – Printed by Thomas Levingston…' Issue 526 is missing such a page. The symbols on image 6 and image 7 probably refer to a tear in the image, as is evident in column four of image 6 and the corresponding column one in 8. As for 1, we cannot be certain, it probably refers to the fair condition of the source.

Content Analysis

Turning to the contents of the source, if we consider issue 284 (image 6-9) as our example, we can see that the paper usually begins with foreign news from Europe and afar. In image 6, it republishes letters from S. Cathalan, Consul of the United States to France, and from Mayor Maurraille, Mayor of Marseilles. Newspapers of this period and before, going back to the first news media of the early modern period, reported the news as despatches and letters received from places afar. By republishing letters, newspapers can preserve

sources that may be otherwise lost. However, as the newspaper indicates, the letter is only an excerpt. There is also no other indication as to what other editorial changes had been made to the letter's text.

Note also that Cathalan's letter is dated (at the top of column one) '1st December 1792', a whole seven months before this issue was published. In a time without electronics or telegrams, newspapers depended on the transport of letters to provide information. In image 6, column four, the *Mirror* notes that 'the Genoese ship Nettuno, latterly arrived at Madras, left the Downs on the 18th Feby, brings the latest European accounts that have yet been received in India', a full five months after. This is to say that historical newspapers exhibit a different sense of temporality than modern newspapers of today, a reminder that contemporaries lived in a society where news that was months old would still be worthy of sharing. Even important news like declarations of war was not immune to delay. When the French declared war on the UK in February 1793, it similarly took five months for the news to reach the Indian subcontinent and for the war there to commence.[19] Although the information may be old, contemporaries found it relevant enough to share and act upon. In this case, the letter concerned trade between France and the USA, information that may have had an impact on the merchant and commercial audience the *Asiatic Mirror* was writing for.

You may have noticed that the 's' in '1st' is printed like an 'f' without a crossbar. This is a 'long s', which was commonly used in English print until the nineteenth century. It functions the same way as a regular 's', and with time and familiarity, you will come to silently correct it in your mind.

The item from Kelso, Scotland, also in image 6 (middle of column three), appears less relevant to the commercial interests of its audience, as is the news from Ireland in the previous column. Perhaps they expressed sentiments that the *Mirror* supported. The reference in the Kelso item to their toast – to 'Liberty of all Mankind, Blacks as well as Whites' – may be useful for a historian examining evidence for support of the abolition of slavery, particularly since the audience of the *Mirror* may include slaveowners or may have invested in slave trading companies.

The local news from the subcontinent appears under the section titles ‘Asiatic Mirror’ (image 6 column three). It lists appointments and material from the military council minutes. This may seem unusual since military appointments appear divorced from commercial concerns. However, reading more about the British in India at this point, we realise that the country was still operating under the auspices of the East India Company (EIC), and the line between military and civilians may be more blurred than we might think. In the printer’s imprint in image 9, there is a message from Levingstone, who asked that ‘those Gentlemen who may be about to change their Stations… give him previous Notice of the same, [so] that no Mistakes may be made in the Dispatch of the paper’. The same too to ‘Gentlemen [in] Calcutta’ so that they may receive the newspaper. The term ‘Stations’ clues us that the newspaper’s subscribers were probably expatriates from the UK working for, or with the EIC.

Occasionally, the source can contain annotations that help us understand more about the reader and user of the material. These could be a date to mark when the item was purchased, or a name to mark ownership or an intended recipient, or simple responses and annotations to the text. In image 14, at the top, we see ‘[F]or Ralph Leeke Esq. / Longford Shropshire’. Shropshire is an English country, so we can try searching for ‘Ralph Leeke’ and ‘Shropshire’ on the UK National Archives’s Discovery service, which allows you to search not only the Archives at Kew but also county and parish records across the country.[20] Our enquiry turns up an item record for the correspondence and papers of ‘Leeke, Ralph (d 1829) East India Co Official’ (dating from 1775 to 1786) and various other material related to Leeke and Longford, all held at the Shropshire Archives.[21] The Shropshire Archives has a record for Longford Hall, in which Colonel Ralph Leeke is described as ‘a political agent of the East India Company’ and ‘a returning nabob without political ambition’.[22] It appears that our hunch is right: the *Mirror* counted among its readers a military man in the employ of the EIC and who made his fortune in India, also known as a nabob. The annotation also implies that the paper was forwarded from Calcutta to England. We might conjecture that Leeke wanted to remain updated on the latest news from the subcontinent. This may also explain how this particular issue, and possibly the others too ended up in the British Library collection, perhaps as part of Leeke’s assets that were donated after his passing.

Back in image 6, the paper moves on to news related to trade, including the observation that ‘The Madras market of this season, for Europe articles, is higher than it has been for two or three years past.’ Other contents related to trade include an editorial piece in image 7, from the middle of column one, which addresses ‘the imperfect system under which the pilotage of the river Hooghly [was] conducted’. The Hooghly is Calcutta’s riverine route to the Bay of Bengal, and the editorial highlighted ‘the late losses’ of shipping on the river, which it blamed on the ‘Marine Establishment of Bengal’ for not furnishing enough experienced pilots. This would be a concern close to the interests of a commercially minded reader.

Information about social life and society in Calcutta can also be found in the source. From image 6, bottom of column four, to the next page 7, is an item announcing the results of ‘Mrs Fay’s Lottery’. Other society items include a description of an upcoming production of ‘Tom Thumb’, the advert from the Calcutta Theatre, with auction events in column four of 7 and sales on the next page, image 8. These auction and sales advertisements contain a wealth of information for economic and material historians: they contain lists of items that were considered valuable enough to advertise, sometimes with prices that can be tracked to calculate measures like inflation and price of living. These lists also paint a vivid image of what contemporaries traded in: ribbons, tea, ‘Patna cossas’ or cotton textiles, alcohol spirits, and even a palanquin used to transport people. Look at image 8, where almost the entire page is filled with items for sale including expensive items like horses, wine, and property. If we see image 11, column two, the theatre production ‘Too Civil By Half’ is advertised with box seats going for ‘One Gold Mohur’ and upper boxes ‘Twelve Rupees’, and also passage to Europe on an American ship, the *Neptune*. We can probably conclude that the target audience for the *Mirror* is moneyed, with the mobility and funds to travel out of the subcontinent.

Another type of item in this paper is the lists of Births, Marriages, and Deaths (image 9 column four, 11 column one, 1 column two). If we had more issues of the paper, it may be possible for a historian to track the movement and life of an individual or their family in Calcutta. In image 2, there is also a list of ships departing, perhaps the section served as a register of this community’s

movements in and out of the city. Without more issues, we can only hypothesise.

The *Mirror* was not the only newspaper in Calcutta, and its readers interacted with other local papers. In image 10, the paper published a reader's letter that served as a response to the previous week's issues of the *World*. Checking back with the British Library's Early English Indian Newspapers record, we see that there is one issue of the *World* in the collection, printed in Calcutta and dated 4 January 1794 – a Saturday as we might expect from a weekly paper. The reader who submitted the letter, Richard Peirce, took offence at the *World* for publishing a report besmirching the name of the late Lieutenant Peirce. Why did Richard Peirce write to the *Mirror*? It appears that the *World* may be prejudiced against his case, and Peirce was not certain his rebuttal would be published. Another reason could also be that the *Mirror* and the *World* shared a similar audience that Peirce was trying to reach, one way or another. Did the *Mirror* print this letter to boost its standing in the local community and its target audience, to the detriment of its competitor the *World*? If we had access to other papers from this week, we could check and see if Peirce had sent the same letter to multiple outlets. Subsequent issues of the *Mirror* would also allow us to follow any developments and responses. While this source suggests intriguing possibilities, we will need to cross-reference it with other sources to test our hypotheses.

Source 2: Harrop's Manchester Mercury

Provenance and Contextual Information

According to the source data provided, these newspapers are held in Chetham's Library in Manchester. Searching through their catalogue, we find three records of 'Harrop's Manchester Mercury' with the same shelf-mark 'MAIN Collection – Shelfmark : Per.' that provide slightly different amounts of description of the sources.[23] From these, we can gather the birth and death dates of the creator Joseph Harrop (1727 or 1728 to 1804). A clearer description of these records can be found in the English Short Title Catalogue (ESTC), a union catalogue that aims to include a record for every surviving

copy of printed material.[24] A search for 'harrop mercury' will pull up ten records, of which three are relevant, ESTC citation numbers P73, P2662, and P2663.[25] For P73, you will find that under 'Dates of publication' there is just one issue, number 278 (5 July 1757). The P2662 and P2663 records are what we are looking for: P2662 covers issues 1–8 (3March 1752 to 21 April 1752), and P2663 contains numbers 9–277 (28 April 1752 to 23 June 1757). The newspaper run is split into two because the title was changed in issue 9 to include 'and General advertiser'. Notice that under 'Copies' for both records, the actual sources in Manchester's Chetham Library are not listed. If you switch the 'Format option' at the top to 'HOLDING DETAILS', you will find that there are copies in McMaster University in Ontario, and one issue 89 in the National Archives in London. This is because the ESTC draws its information not necessarily from the actual archive where the source is located but also from microform copies in libraries all around the world. In this case, these ESTC records exist because the newspaper has a microform copy at McMaster, and the McMaster catalogue record information was imported into the ESTC. Another version of these two records exists in the British Library's catalogue.[26] The records indicate the BL has microform copies of the newspaper. Under the 'I want this' tab (which shows you how to access these sources), you can also see that the microforms have been digitised under the *British Newspaper Archive* (BNA) project. Following the link to the BNA database, you can find a written description of the *Mercury* and of Joseph Harrop, 'a staunch Tory… [who] supported the status quo… and strongly opposed parliamentary reform'.[27]

Notice that the BNA images are digital scans of the microforms and are hence rendered in black-and-white. Our own source images are in colour as the original sources themselves were digitised under another initiative by Chetham's Library in partnership with Adam Matthew. By going straight to the source rather than through a microform, you can get a better representation of the actual condition of the documents and a sense of the texture, all details that are lost when seen in microform.

Initial Evaluation

Go through the source images quickly. You may notice that in some of the images, in particular 34, the text on the right side is warped and occasionally unreadable at the margins. These periodicals, originally sold as loose issues, have been bound into a volume by their collector or by the archive itself. Binding newspapers into volumes is a common practice: it keeps loose issues together, making them less prone to loss and easier to store, retrieve and account for. Unfortunately, sometimes the binding comes too close to the margins of the source. Image 35 is particularly problematic; we lose entire words and letters in the left margin. This problem is magnified when working with digitised microforms, which do not provide the same level of resolution as the colour images we are working with here, which make margin text even harder to read. In some instances, you may be able to make an educated guess and fill in the missing letters or word, indicating your intervention with square brackets, that is, 'other [Pub]lick Dancing, Musick, &c.'. The guiding principle is to make sure your reader knows exactly what text is missing where, and which parts of your quotation are your own qualified interventions so they can make their own judgement.

If you look at the top right corner of 35, you will see the number '18'. Two images later in 37, there is a '19'. This sequential numbering continues every other page. This is known as foliation, a process where individual leaves of paper in a box or collection are numbered in order, on the front of the leaf – also known as the recto side. The backside of the leaf is known as the verso side. It does not have a foliation number because it is just the same sheet of paper as the reverse side: images 35 and 36 are two pages on the same leaf of paper. If you were referencing image 35 as the original item in Manchester, you would cite it as 'f.18r'. The 'f.' stands for 'folio number', '18' is the foliation number indicated, and 'r' means 'recto' or the front side of the leaf. The reverse side, image 36, would thus be cited as 'f.18v'. Earlier early modern print material, including newsbooks, were often in quarto format (see above for our discussion of folio and quarto book sizes). For these, we usually use the printer's signature marks, which were letters, symbols, and numbers at the bottom of each page that helped a binder assemble the book in the correct order. Each large sheet of paper would be assigned a letter, and each of its four leaves a number in the sequence. The eight pages of a quarto book would have its eight pages cited thus: A1r, A1v, A2r, A2v, A3r, A3v, A4r, A4v. A printer could add a second sheet of paper to make a book of 16 pages, and the added pages would have these signature marks: B1r, B1v, B2r, B2v, B3r, B3v, B4r, B4v.

Foliation numbers can also help us understand the condition of the collection when it was first accessioned. Browsing the images, we can see that each issue of *Mercury* comprised of two leaves, containing four pages in total. Each page is represented by an image in this digital collection. Going through the complete set of images, we find that issues 4, 26, 42, 52, and 60 are missing a leaf each. These would be two missing images between image 14-15, 98–99, 162–163, 200–201, and 230–231. However, the foliation numbers on the leaves are all in sequence. Assuming the leaves were given foliation numbers when they first entered the archive, we can tell that the missing pages were already lost when the collection was created.

Content Analysis

In image 1, in the first item of the first issue of the *Mercury*, Harrop explained why he started the newspaper. He cited how he had been 'greatly encourag'd' by others 'to publish a Weekly News-Paper', and now that he had 'procur'd a new Set of Types to print with' he could try and fulfil his 'honest Desire of Employment in [his] proper Calling, in the Place of [his] Nativity'. With the paper he intended to 'give [the Public] all the Satisfaction that [he can], and no just Cause of Offence whatsoever'. Seeking 'Countrymen' who would support him with 'Subscriptions', it appears that Harrop was one of the rare examples of a printer, seller, and editor put together. This would only have been possible with Harrop's pre-existing wealth, which would have been enough to purchase the set of types and to set up shop 'opposite the Exchange' in Manchester (image 4). The paper was also to be funded through advertisements, and potentially other printing work done in 'the neatest and cheapest Manner'.

Who were the audience of the *Mercury*? In image 4, we see the price of corn in Manchester listed. These prices are regularly listed, appearing in images 8, 12, 18, and more. Lists of bankrupts also appear, like in image 12. In image 109, you can see a list of trade between France and the Port of London. Like the lists of items for sale in the *Asiatic Mirror*, this list is a treasure trove for material and economic historians, and also global historians who are interested in understanding the transnational movement of goods and trade flows.

Unfortunately, this appears to be the only instance of this data in the collection. We may be able to find similar information in other newspapers produced for a commercial audience, or perhaps in guild and municipal archives. At the bottom, we see another reference to ‘our Exports of Corn and Meal’. Perhaps the audience was comprised of landowning individuals who profited off the sale of agricultural produce. There are also regular items featuring Lloyd’s List (as in image 17), which contain details of recent ship arrivals at ports around the British Isles and the Caribbean. Advertisements can help elucidate more detail. In image 182, we see an advertisement for a dance school for ‘young Gentlemen and Ladies’. In image 182, an auction of books is advertised, and in 785, a book explaining the Charter of Liverpool is promoted. In image 216, a medical book ‘The General Dispensatory’ (‘Necessary for every Family’) and ‘The Never-failing Anti-Epileptic Drops’ are advertised. The drops are sold in Liverpool, Chester, Ormskirk, Preston, Warrington, Knotsford, Nottingham, Prescot, Lancaster – almost all of which are in North-West England. In image 286, the front page is a list of donors to the Manchester Infirmary. This evidence suggests an audience that is wealthy, landed, involved in trade, and who live with families around the North-West region.

Having a continuous run of issues helps illustrate a paper’s more unusual or seasonal inclusions. In image 157, the paper published several Christmas hymns to mark the season. The season is also marked by entertainment provided by travelling curiosities. In image 160, at the top of column one, we see an advertisement for ‘Mr. Furmstom, the modern living Colossus or wonderful Giant’, a ‘Phenomenon in Nature’ that outshone his rivals ‘the Sussex Boy’ and ‘the Swedish Lump of Irregularity’, available to view ‘during the Holy-days’. On the same page, a second item advertised a trio of acrobats, including ‘a young Indian’ who could balance a multitude of chairs while balancing himself on his head on a pyramid of other chairs. These two adverts are accompanied by woodcuts, which illustrated their main attraction. Woodcuts seem to be used predominantly to promote entertainment events, probably because they draw visual attention in a sea of newspaper text. In image 190, we see an image of two cocks fighting, which was used to promote a series of battles ‘at the New Pit’ over several days. Woodcuts are essentially blocks of wood carved with an image, which would appear when the ink was applied and the woodblock was pressed onto the paper. Looking through the various issues, such images were comparatively rare. It could be that these were supplied or commissioned by the advertiser.

The other main use of a woodcut image is in the masthead of the *Mercury*, which was introduced in issue 9 and reused every issue after.

In these advertisements we can also discern what contemporaries thought was tasteful or respectable. In image 298, an advertisement about a 'Young Rhinoceros' beckons the reader to see 'this surprising Creature… clothed in real Coat of Armour'. The description embellishes the animal's credentials, stating that it had 'been seen with the highest Satisfaction by most of the greatest Personages in Europe, as well as the greater Part of the Royal Society'. The item about the giant Mr Furmstom similarly mentions how he had been 'inspected by great numbers of Nobility, Gentry, … Lovers of Natural Curiosities' (image 182). With two distinct examples, we can hypothesise that contemporaries could be swayed by appeals to status and celebrity, as well as the scientific establishment. To see these curiosities was to imitate the actions of the greatest personalities and minds in society.

Like the *Mirror*, the *Mercury* republished news from around the world, marking them clearly as information received through the post. See, for example, image 4, where the news from London in 'Tuesday Morning's Post' carried information about Oxford, 'a great Earthquake in Turkey', a lottery in Ireland, and a debate in Parliament.

Conclusion

Before we started looking at the sources in earnest, we began first by trying to understand the institutional and archival history of these sources. This provides important context that frames the way we understand these newspapers. These sources did not emerge in a vacuum; they were created by people with opinions and values, for an audience that had specific expectations of the newspaper, its style, and its content.

Having surveyed the external contextual evidence that we gathered from secondary sources and archival records, we then turned to the sources themselves. Casting a quick eye over the material, we looked at the format

and main features of the sources. We paid attention to how the text and images were laid out, making sure to understand how readers would have seen the newspaper in its entirety. Surveying the content to understand what kinds of material was being included, we drew several hypotheses about the audience and the creators of the newspapers. We made these inferences based on our contextual knowledge of the local area and of the culture of the time. Opinion pieces and references to other newspapers are also helpful in building a picture of how the newspaper fits in the media landscape of the time. We also made note of any evidence of reader reception, particularly of any annotations on the source that can give us insight into how the newspaper was read and understood, or even who the source was procured for.

As we have seen, newspapers offer a wide array of different types of information useful to historians studying matters of economics, political, material, and social history. The evidence we have seen suggests to us several preliminary hypotheses about the papers themselves and the people it reached. As historians, we must now proceed to cross-reference this material and to test these hypotheses with other sources, newspapers or otherwise.

Post-evaluation Questions

1. How do newspapers differ from magazines and other periodical literature?

2. How might we use editorial items differently from advertisements and news items?

3. How can we go about ascertaining the authorship of a newspaper?

4. Do newspapers reflect true public opinion? How might they voice the opinions of those without power and access to education?

5. Why do some newspapers survive, and others disappear? Why are some newspapers represented in the archives and not others?

6. Do historians work differently with weekly newspapers than with daily newspapers? How might a more regular publishing schedule change a newspaper's value as a historical source?

Further Research Considerations

If you were to research this area further, you might consider the following questions and discussion points:

1. How might we use newspaper sources in conjunction with more scholarly works of research?

2. What challenges lie ahead for the preservation of today's newspapers?

3. What happens when authorship is complicated or unclear? Can we still use a newspaper as an effective source?

4. How might we study the material history of the newspaper? How has the value of the newspaper as a material object changed over time?

5. How do newspapers sources differ from other sources of popular media, like radio, television, and the internet?

6. Do newspapers printed in languages other than English pose different challenges?

Further Resources

Primary Sources

Historic American Newspapers: https://chroniclingamerica.loc.gov/

Australian newspapers by the National Library of Australia: https://trove.nla.gov.au/newspaper/

Welsh Newspapers: https://newspapers.library.wales/

London, Belfast, and Edinburgh Gazette: https://www.thegazette.co.uk/

Reference and Secondary Sources

Nelson, Carolyn W., and Matthew Seccombe, *British newspapers and periodicals, 1641–1700*, New York, NY: Modern Language Association of America, 1987.

Raymond, Joad, *Invention of the Newspaper: English Newsbooks, 1641–1649*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996.

Dobson, Miriam, and Benjamin Ziemann, eds. *Reading Primary Sources*. London: Routledge, 2009.

Potter, Simon J., *News and the British World: The Emergence of an Imperial Press System*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 2003.

Boyce, George, James Curran, and Pauline Wingate, eds. *Newspaper History from the Seventeenth Century to the Present Day.* London: Constable, 1978.

Notes

1. See Raymond, *The Invention of the Newspaper.*

2. Baumgartner, “Newspapers as Historical Sources,” 257.

3. Vella, “Newspapers.”

4. Raymond, *The Invention of the Newspaper.*

5. Knudson, “Late to the Feast: Newspapers as Historical Sources.”

6. Nelson and Seccombe, *Periodical Publications 1641–1700.*

7. The idea of a public arena of debate that shapes the direction of society, outside of the previous forums of church and the court, is expressed in its most traditional sense by J. Habermas’s idea of a ‘public sphere’. Habermas, *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere*.

8. Vella, “Newspapers,” 194–6.

9. ‘Whiggish histories’ are histories that depict the past as an inevitable progression towards enlightenment and liberty. These teleological histories are problematic because they hide the contingency of past events, and they elide over the complexity of historical actors and situations. Take for example the Magna Carta. Signed by King John of England, this document is often described as the foundational document of democracy and a charter of rights, including the right for all ‘free men’ to a fair trial. In truth, the Magna Carta was a peace treaty between a king and his rebellious barons, and the ‘free men’ clause only applied to the barons who hoped to avoid being unilaterally punished by King John. The document itself was not written as part of a conscious desire to promote civil liberties and move towards enlightenment.

10. Vella, “Newspapers,” 196–8.

11. Other practical concerns included more prosaic ones like using complicated microfilm machines, eye strain from viewing microfilm, and even the skill of the indexer. See Wilkinson, “At the Coal-Face of History.” Microfilm is one type of microform, see our later discussion in the source evaluation.

12. Bingham, “Ignoring the First Draft of History?”

13. Dyas, “Newspaper Archives.”

14. Dyas, “Newspaper Archives”, *passim*. The ephemeral and transient nature of news and the newspapers themselves affect the way the industry understood their archives as more of a library of past issues, rather than as an institutional archive that helps reconstruct their processes.

15. Bingham, “The Digitization of Newspaper Archives.”

16. Nicholson, “The Digital Turn.”

17. British Library, “Early Indian Newspapers.”

18. British Library, “The Asiatic Mirror, and Commercial Advertiser.”

19. Northcote, *War in the Eastern Seas, 1793-1815*, 60.

20. Try this yourself at https://discovery.nationalarchives.gov.uk/

21. The National Archives, “Leeke, Ralph (d 1829) East India Co Official. Correspondence and papers.”

22. Shropshire Archives, “Longford Hall, Longford.”

23. Try it yourself at Chetham Library’s Printed Material Catalogue: https://chethams.inforlib.uk/iguana01/www.main.cls

24. A union catalogue combines records from other published catalogues. The ESTC combines information from libraries around the world, see the project description at https://www.bl.uk/projects/english-short-title-catalogue

25. Try it yourself at ESTC hosted by the British Library: http://estc.bl.uk/

26. British Library catalogue: http://explore.bl.uk/ A search on the National Archive's Discovery catalogue does not show any of Harrop's newspapers, primarily because the BL is responsible for the vast majority of pre-twentieth century print material.

27. British Newspaper Archive, "Manchester Mercury."

Bibliography

Bingham, Adrian. “Newspapers as Historical Sources.” *Philippine Quarterly of Culture and Society* 9, no. 3 (1981): 256–8.

Bingham, Adrian. “The Digitization of Newspaper Archives: Opportunities and Challenges for Historians.” *Twentieth Century British History* 21, no. 2 (2010): 225–31.

Bingham, Adrian. “Ignoring the First Draft of History? Searching for the Popular Press in Studies of Twentieth-Century Britain.” *Media History* 18, no. 3-4 (2012): 311–2.

British Library. “The Asiatic Mirror, and Commercial Advertiser.” *Explore the Catalogue*. Accessed December 12, 2020. http://explore.bl.uk/BLVU1:LSCOP-ALL:BLL01013905198.

British Library. “Early Indian Newspapers.” *Help for Researchers*. Accessed December 12, 2020. http://vll-minos.bl.uk/reshelp/findhelprestype/news/einews/index.html.

British Newspaper Archive. “Manchester Mercury.” Accessed December 12, 2020. https://www.britishnewspaperarchive.co.uk/titles/manchester-mercury.

Knudson, J.W. “Late to the Feast: Newspapers as Historical Sources.” *Perspectives on History*. Accessed December 12, 2020. https://www.historians.org/publications-and-directories/perspectives-on-history/october-1993/late-to-thefeast

.

Nelson, C., and Matthew Seccombe. *Periodical Publications 1641-1700: A Survey with Illustrations*. London: The Bibliographical Society, 1986.

Nicholson, B. "The Digital Turn: Exploring the Methodological Possibilities of Digital Newspaper Archives." *Media History* 19, no. 1 (2013): 59–73.

Parkinson, C. Northcote. *War in the Eastern Seas, 1793-1815*. London: George Allen & Unwin Ltd, 1954.

Raymond, Joad. *The Invention of the Newspaper: English Newsbooks 1641-1649*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005.

Shropshire Archives. "Longford Hall, Longford." Accessed December 12, 2020. http://search.shropshirehistory.org.uk/collections/getrecord/CCS_MSA561/ .

The National Archives. "Leeke, Ralph (d 1829) East India Co Official. Correspondence and Papers." *Discovery*. Accessed December 12, 2020. https://discovery.nationalarchives.gov.uk/details/r/N13812064.

Vella, Stephen. "Newspapers." In *Reading Primary Sources*, edited by Miriam Dobson, and Benjamin Ziemann, 192–208. London: Routledge, 2010.

Wilkinson, Glenn R. "At the Coal-Face of History: Personal Reflections on Using Newspapers as a Source." *Media History* 3, no. 1-2 (1995): 211–21.